

SC301 – Rethinking Modernity Revision notes

Preparation for the examination

- Organise notes by topic including class notes, notes on wider readings, and annotation of textbooks and other books. These revision notes provide only the briefest outline of the topics concerned for the revision sessions.
- You might want to use Post-It notes to organise parts of the books that you are going to bring into the examination (for limitations on number of books see rubric below).
- Maybe practice writing an essay, or even paragraphs, on a particular topic before the examination so that you can get an idea of how to structure your time.

Exam technique

- Stick to the 'rubric' carefully (see next page)
- The examination is not designed to 'trick' you but to test you. It should be clear which questions relate to which areas of the course. You should be able to show that you relate the key ideas / theorists / concepts to the relevant essay, but you can (and should) also bring in other ideas / theorists / concepts where relevant from across the module.
- Plan the essay.
- Essays should follow a clear structure. An introduction that defines key ideas and sets out the argument, a logically organised main body, and a conclusion that directly answers the question.
- Pay attention to the words in the question (such as evaluate / analyse / critique) and the substantive theorists / theories in the question. Know how theorists group together in terms of perspectives / arguments and what are the counter-arguments.
- Develop a clear argument rather than focus on description. Use key sociological concepts and theories.
- Answer the question directly.
- Critical evaluation is essential: understand the difference between critique / criticism.
- Think about how theories can work together.
- Use your sociological imagination linking key ideas / theories.
- Pay attention to spelling, punctuation and grammar.
- Use the time allocation wisely. Each essay is worth the same percentage of the marks.

Exam Rubric

SC301-6-FY

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Undergraduate Examination 2026

RETHINKING MODERNITY

Time allowed: **THREE** hours

An open-book exam allows you to refer to your notes and other course materials while you are taking the exam. Open-book exams are designed to test your ability to analyse, evaluate or synthesise knowledge, rather than your ability to recall facts or information.

You may bring physical written or printed notes, textbooks, dictionaries or course materials into the exam room. Please note that your materials must fit on a small desk and you are advised to bring well-structured notes based on revision topics.

You may not bring electronic devices except calculators of the following types only: Casio FX-83GT or Casio FX-85GT series only (CW, X, PLUS). All Sociology exams will be paper-based and hand-written.

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions in total. **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B**, and **ONE** other from **EITHER SECTION**.

The paper consists of **SEVENTEEN** questions in total.

All questions are of equal weight.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator. Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room. Do not open the question paper until told to do so.

All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided.

All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided.

A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked.

At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

Your response must be your own work. Procedures are in place to detect plagiarism.

This paper is restricted and must not be removed from the examination room. Please use treasury tag to attach question paper to answer booklet.

Section A (Autumn Term): Revision Notes

1. Rethinking Modernity

- The concepts below provide a set of conceptual tools for thinking about a variety of sociological theories.

Modernity as a Contested Concept

- Modernity is conventionally associated with rationality and industrialisation as part of the economic / social / cultural development of Europe.
- Some sociological analysis sees this as being a process of exploitation / immiseration / colonialism / international trade / violence.
- Modernity is hence a global and relational phenomena, not just a result of European (or American) exceptionalism
- Modernity is not a neutral process but one involving coercion and unequal exchange
- Myth of progress

Modernity and Colonialism

- Modernity as a colonial project – extraction and exploitation. Racialised labour.
- Transnational slavery and resource extraction as key to modernity / capitalism
- Colonialism shaped intellectual and moral frameworks, legitimised perspectives
- Modernity involves relationships of global interdependence
- This is through trade (including slave trade) and transnational flows of people, goods, capital and ideas
- Non-European people were key to the process of globalisation and modernity in terms of both support and resistance.

Sociological Canon

- The Sociological Canon is the set of foundational thinkers of Classical Sociology.
- This Canon prioritises European thought. The production of sociological knowledge is shaped by power and privilege.
- Rethinking the Canon incorporates a set of thinkers who consider issues such as race, colonialism and inequality. This is not just to add ‘diversity’ but reshapes theoretical frameworks.

The Sociological Imagination

- Sociological imagination involves alternative ways to conceptualise social relations and theories.
- In contemporary theory, the sociological imagination becomes an active part of reinterpreting and changing the world.
- Imagination is key to theoretical innovation, against ‘common sense’ modes of thinking.

Language, Knowledge, and Power

- Language is not neutral but a tool of power and representation.
- It reinforces hierarchies and determines which knowledge(s) are taken to be valid.
- It shapes how reality is perceived and lived.

Critique, Transformation, Bifurcation and Division

- Criticism concerns finding flaws and weaknesses. Critique is a deeper evaluative mode of thinking involving evaluating structures, assumptions and possibilities. It can point towards alternative futures.
- Bifurcation is a dominant mode of modern thought involving splitting a phenomenon into binary / often opposing categories (male / female, white / black, language / reality, fact / value)
- This mode of thinking is overtly simplistic and can obscure complexity
- Modernist concepts are frequently bifurcated.
- Bifurcation is a critique of how knowledge is organised in modernity.
- Understanding these problematics can enable us to innovate theoretically and conceptually

2. Is Modernity a Colonial Project?

Modernity and the Eurocentric sociological project

- Modernity is associated with progress / rationality / development / enlightenment
- Definitions of modernity tend to marginalise alternative experience
- One way of looking at modernity is as a way of thinking / organising life
- Positions non-European societies as 'lacking' (progress / rationality / liberal values)
- The 'sociological project' (sociology) is a product of modernity focussing on industrialisation / a certain mode of capitalist development and production / urbanity / individualism, Marx – capitalism and industrialisation, Weber – rationality and bureaucracy, Durkheim – simple to complex societies and forms of solidarity.
- Classical (and often modern) sociology focuses on European societies and processes.
- Sociology is often Eurocentric and its lens on other societies is that they are traditional / pre-modern / backward.
- Sociology may ironically reproduce the sorts of inequalities it aims to challenge.

Colonialism, modernity and thought

- The Colonial Attitude concerns thinking in bifurcated terms about superior / inferior societies.
- It produces social / cultural hierarchies that continue beyond colonialism as a political project
- Colonialism and modernity produce a hierarchical understanding of time / historical development and consciousness with some societies assumed to be static or cyclical and others progressive. Temporality plays an important part in continued hierarchies.
- Modernity and colonialism make claims about cultural universalism that shape knowledge production and the formation of ideas and theories.
- Modernity is normatively related to capitalism (capitalist modernity) rather than other modernisms or futurisms (such as Afrofuturism)

Dussel's critique of Eurocentric Modernity

- Enrique Dussel claims modernity is shaped by Eurocentrism. Dominant theories suggest that modernity is exclusively European rather than global. These theories assume that there is one, Eurocentric, route to economic growth, social development and cultural enrichment.
- Modernity presents itself as rational and emancipatory, but it involves domination and is exploitative. European modernity is based on violence.
- Europeans see it as a moral / social duty to educate and emancipate other global societies.
- Support for this argument comes from an analysis of Kant and Hegel's views on race and European superiority. Kant associates the enlightenment with the use of reason by European people, and dismisses those from other racial groups. Hegel presents the movement of world history through the progressive dialectic of ideas based in Europe.

3. Animals, Society and Modernity

Early Sociological Views on Animals

- Animals were part of classical sociology but treated as marginal / peripheral.
- Durkheim suggested animals could exhibit social behaviour and that their sociability might emerge from their social conditions rather than being innate or akin to humans.
- Weber accepted that animals could show emotion and respond to human emotions, but he defined social action in interpretivist sociology as something that animals could not be part of. We can only attach meaning to human actions, only understand other human intentions and only act in relation to human values and motives. So there is a contradiction in that animals can emote, and relate to emotions, but are separate from understandings in traditional interpretivist sociology.
- Marx remarked on the productive capacity of other animals, such as bees, but thought that there was something exceptional about human society / labour. Greene argues that animals were central to industrialisation / modernity (horsepower), enabling the production of commodities and the circulation of goods. This can be seen as part of a wider problem for Marxists (and others) in neglecting the non-human sources of exploitation and oppression. Animals are used in agriculture, industry and research today.
- These early ideas were often not developed. For example, Parsons defined functionalist sociology as a human discipline.

Human exceptionalism and bifurcation

- Human exceptionalism is the idea that humans are superior and distinct to animals.
- Humans have unique capabilities of rational thought, morality and consciousness.
- Animals are objects, possessions and pets, lower in the 'chain of being', misusing Darwinist ideas of evolution
- There is a bifurcation between the human and the animal
- Carter and Charles argue that this limits sociological understanding. Humans are social actors and animals are part of the realm of nature. Life is seen as disconnected.

Reconceptualising animals as a sociological problem and 'animal studies'

- Carter and Charles argue that animals are constitutive of society, not marginal or external to it. Animals are agents, part of social organisation and subject to societal exploitation.
- Animal studies argues that animals are a constitutive part of society and should be incorporated into sociological analysis. Humans are animals too. Animal studies can be seen as a more general expansion of the sociological project towards inclusion.
- Donna Harraway argues that humans and animals are relationally linked as 'companion species', challenging binary and bifurcated thinking. Humans become humans through their relations with animals. This involves an understanding of relationality / affect and the multispecies nature of societies.
- Animals may be considered to possess what were previously thought of as human capacities such as culture, communication and agency.
- Alexandra Kimbo encourages methodologies / theories which involve thinking with animals rather than against them / despite them.
- This turn to 'animal studies' raises questions about our ethical treatment of animals

4. Language and the World

Language, thought and reality

- Sapir-Whorf hypothesis: linguistic relativity, language is how people perceive and organise the world. Speakers of a shared language share an understanding of reality that is common.
- Language is not neutral, it shapes how we perceive the world.
- Linguistic relativity (weak form) – language influences thought / perception.
- Linguistic determinism (strong form) – language determines what can be thought. Would limit communication across languages / translation.
- 'Words for snow' debate. Problematic – Eskimo itself is a problematic us / them label and way of thinking. Suggests separate realities (colonialist / bifurcated?) Concentrates on single word, rather than more complex phrasing / nuance.
- Language is not just classificatory / mode of thinking but is evaluative a mode of power.

Language and gender / sexuality

- Dale Spener argues language is structured by male dominance (man-made language), English presents man as the norm, female in relation to this norm. Male experience is seen as neutral / objective / primary – female as emotional / subjective / secondary. Male forms of language are privileged (manmade / manpower).
- Simone de Beauvoir – man as universal / human subject, woman as 'the other', Male perspective seen as neutral, female perspective marked as particular rather than universal. Lived experience as being a woman is central to the argument, not nature or nurture arguments.

Language and Colonialism

- Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o – language as tool of imperialism, colonial systems prioritised European languages and cultures and suppressed indigenous. Language carries power and marginalises local identities / culture. Language is tied to cultural identity and linguistic colonialism can displace meaning. Language is a form of epistemic power,

determines what is recognised as knowledge. European languages are based on histories of hierarchies / inequalities.

- In contrast, Chinua Achebe argues English can be Africanised and reshaped to allow for wider communication / expression.

5. A Question of Experience? Feminism and Social Theory

Early Feminist theory

- First wave feminism focused on equality / rights as part of enlightenment view of extension of rights. Wollstonecraft argued for equal access to education / citizenship. This perspective is known as liberal feminism. Focused on rights rather than experience.

Experience as a form of feminist knowledge.

- Simone de Beauvoir in *The Second Sex* (1949) focusses on the lived experience of being a woman, that woman is something that 'becomes' through social processes / lived experience. Woman is seen as the 'other' / secondary / derivative and man as the norm / primary / absolute. Complex relationship between gender / sex and experience.
- Second wave feminist slogan – the personal is political – experience operates in overt / covert ways and across multiple public / private domains.
- Patriarchy - male dominance embedded in social structures / institutions divides the world into the public and private spheres. Public – paid work / economic production, private – home / domestic life / forms of social reproduction. Focus on aesthetic and emotional labour in this sphere. Walby and Hall separately refer to how this presents women as domestic / consumers rather than public / producers. Women experience patriarchal oppression.
- Nancy Hartsock argues that women occupy a unique social position. They are insiders as their labour is essential to society but outsiders as they do not have power within it. This gives then particular insight, and shared experience, of patriarchy. This is a potential source of critical knowledge. This is feminist standpoint theory.

Problems of universalising women / women's experience

- Women don't all share the same experience of oppression. This is essentialist (fixed identity as a woman), ahistorical and exclusionary (ignores race / class / sexuality / gender identity / histories)
- Black Feminist Thought: Patricia Hill Collins develops Black Feminist Thought and the concept of a 'matrix of domination' different forms of power / oppression (race / gender / class) interact and reinforce (or partially negate) each other. Kimberlé Crenshaw – intersectionality and the shaping of gender by other forces. bell hooks on intersectionality ('Class Matters') and resistance (teaching to transgress / the oppositional gaze). Patricia Hill-Collins challenges idea of home / domestic sphere as oppressive – can be a site of resistance / identity.
- Judith Butler – post-structuralist feminism. 'Woman' is not a stable / coherent category. Gender shaped through language but categories / identities / signifiers are unstable. Unified subject of 'woman' implies exclusions (Queer Theory plays particular attention to this point).

6. Standpoint, Perspectives and Epistemology

Traditional epistemology and critique

- The study of knowledge – how we know what we know and how this is supported / justified
- Traditional epistemology assumes that knowledge is independent of the knower (objective, neutral, independent). Observer and observed are independent of each other.
- Critique is that knowledge is shaped by social position. Not that knowledge is false, but that there are different views / epistemologies.
- Traditional epistemology concerns objectivity either philosophical (external reality independent of human perception) or methodological (neutral / value free). Harding calls these ‘objectivism’ and argues that they are not free of biases.
- Harding – knowledge has been dominated by men and conceals assumptions / vested interests.
- Caroline Criado Perez – knowledge defined in reference to men (‘reference man’) – for example crash test dummies / pharmaceuticals based on a male ‘reference’ body type which others differ from.
- Harding – feminist knowledge is situated, constructed and partial – enables a more accurate view of the world.
- Hartsock / Harding – standpoint theory (inside vs outside perspective). Standpoint is also dependent on developing a critical perspective.
- Situated Knowledge – all knowledge emerges from a particular position, no view from ‘nowhere’. Every perspective shaped by social / cultural / historical conditions.

Perspectival approach

- A perspectival approach acknowledges that different groups perceive the world differently. Brining perspectives together produces not one objective position but different perspectives on the same field. This challenges binary thinking / bifurcation.

Race and post-colonial viewpoints

- Gilroy - The Black Atlantic – case for reconstructing modernity from the views / perspectives of enslaved people who have been previously excluded from discourse / knowledge. bell hooks – oppositional gaze, looking / looking back as an act of resistance.

7. Foucault on Power and Disciplinary Society

Power

- For Foucault power is not about (just) ideology / ruling class control. Power operates through everyday practices, knowledges and institutions. Through the ways in which people are observed, judged, educated and shaped.
- Sovereign power is about direct force / punishment by a sovereign power.
- Modern power is disciplinary working through surveillance, shaping conduct and examination / judgement (Discipline and Punish). This is subtle as it encourages

people to behave in certain ways. Power becomes dispersed and routinised rather than concentrated in rulers, or in state institutions.

- Power is productive, it produces modes of knowledge and behaviour and types of people. Foucault focusses on power / knowledge rather than direct forms of rule.

The Panopticon and Surveillance

- Bentham's panopticon is used by Foucault as a method of modern, disciplinary power. People are watched but they can't tell how / when are being watched.
- Surveillance becomes internalised. People monitor themselves and this extends beyond prisons to other social institutions.
- People are monitored in hierarchical ways (hierarchical observation) are examined (tested and documented) and compared against standards of what is 'normal' (normalising judgement). The invention of the 'normal' becomes a mode of disciplinary society by which people judge themselves to this standard, and to others.
- This produces docile bodies, useful, obedient and self-regulating. Power works at a deep level – but it is not deterministic.

The body and subjectivity in Foucauldian theory

- Susan Bordo argues that norms of health shape bodies in terms of ideas of shape, slenderness, control and self-management. These standards change historically. There is constant pressure to behave in line with (shifting) norms. Women are particularly subject to these norms.
- Judith Butler argues that power actually forms the subject, people depend on power for their existence as a subject because power creates identities. Power is difficult to resist but 'queer theory' argues that it might be troubled (Butler – *Gender Trouble*).

8. A Question of Experience? “Race” and Social Theory

Scientific racism

- Early conceptions of difference originally had no biological referent. They became a category tied to biology in the 19th Century with a 'racial science' (to justify slavery and colonialism) with pseudo-scientific alleged differences in intelligence / character / morality / physiognomy. This was the basis of modern, scientific, racism and eugenics.
- Knowledge was connected with power in racial classification.

W.E.B. Du Bois

- Challenges biological race whilst foregrounding reality of racial experience as a social fact (*Dusk of Dawn*), not an essence but experienced in terms of unequal treatment (Jim Crow). Connects this to experience of slavery / modernity and creation of racial divisions.
- Later this concept was used as 'racial realism' in CRT (Critical Race Theory)
- *Souls of Black Folk* – argues that separation from white people by the 'veil' of race, excluded from dominant world whilst forced to live within it.
- Double Consciousness – looking at oneself through the eyes of others (contempt or pity), a twoness, split in self (this was contrary to contemporary sociology of that time)

- Paul Gilroy in the Black Atlantic claims that Modernity / world is shaped by African people through resistance, slavery and cultural exchange. Challenge to ethnic / nationalistic models of history. Africa is central to modernity.

Whiteness and othering

- Whiteness is not just a racial 'identity' but a form of power although there are many conceptions / intersections of this and arguments concerning the extent and operation of white privilege / white supremacy.
- Toni Morrison states that race / whiteness creates the concept of the 'Other' – othering. Race as an effect of power, for the dominant group to stabilise its own identity – whiteness.
- American identity is tied to whiteness, reinforced by media and culture / law and order / religion.
- Critical Race Theory (CRT) claims that US is still a white supremacist society and that there is a myth of racial progress. The School to Prison pipeline, Prisons and the Army are a modern form of Black Slavery. Racial progress is always pushed back, and only occurs through 'interest convergence' (when it is in white interests). Counter-storytelling can be used as a methodology to reveal Black epistemologies. Gilroy also argues that history needs to be re-written to centre Black / African perspectives.

9. Post-Colonial Theory

The Colonial and the Post-Colonial

- Colonialism involves various processes such as settlement / occupation of land and displacement of indigenous populations, economic relationships of exploitation / appropriation and unequal political / cultural / social power relations.
- Post-colonial theory argues colonialism was central to modernity. Howard French argues this was central to the making of the modern world.
- Re-thinking modernity from other perspectives is important to sociological thinking.
- Hall – West defined itself against 'the Rest' through binary oppositions – rational / irrational, civilised / savage, mind / body, science / magic etc. These oppositions create hierarchies.

Edward Said and Orientalism

- The Orient is not just a geographical place, but a discursive construction produced through scholarship / art / politics.
- Represents the 'East' as different / inferior from the 'West'
- The Orient became Europe's contrasting Other – mysterious, exotic, irrational and decadent. Creation of false binaries.
- Shaped by Foucauldian discourse, not just to describe but as a mode of knowledge / power to rule politically and scientifically.

Chandra Mohanty and critique of universalism

- Categories such as 'Third World Woman' are constructed by the West in homogenous ways – as poor, ignorant and powerless.
- Allows Western women to appear as affluent, knowledgeable and agentic.
- Women do not experience patriarchy / oppression in the same way.

Frantz Fanon and the existential dimensions of colonisation

- In *Black Skin / White Masks* Fanon describes how colonial power denies subjectivity to the colonised and turns them into objects under the eyes of the coloniser
- When a white child points and Fanon and labels using a racial slur, he shows how that child penetrates the illusion of what is always present (racism) and how he becomes visible and dissected under white eyes. He experiences himself as both subject and object.
- Post-colonial struggle involves reclaiming identity and voice.
- Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, raises the problem of whether the oppressed and colonised (subaltern) can express themselves, and under what conditions, without being simplified, appropriated, or silenced again.

10. Ways of Seeing. Vision, Knowledge and Power

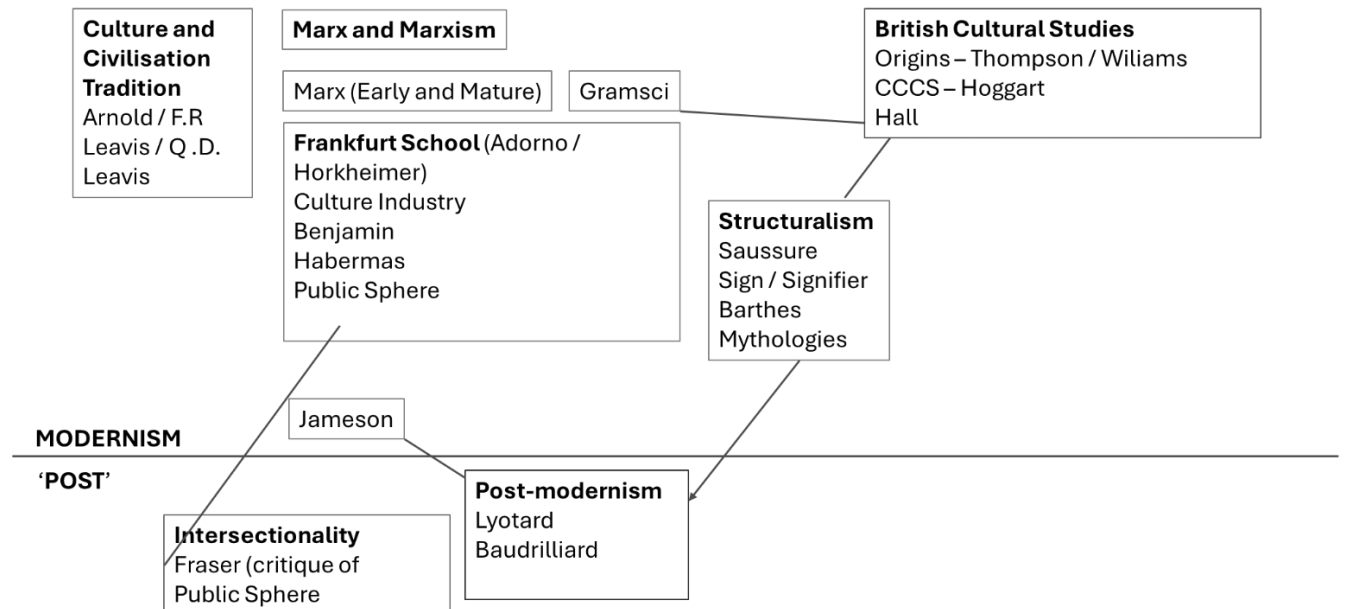
Vision and representation

- Visual representations don't just reflect reality they organise and construct it
- Schroder argues to look (the gaze) is not neutral but to hold power over what is seen.
- Colonial powers employed, and still employ, the gaze (in extreme, Human Zoos) and in mapping / bordering / boundaries / surveillance
- bell hooks argues that oppressed people have been denied the right 'to look' and the gaze can be oppositional (oppositional gaze)
- Haraway recognises the gaze is always partial / situated and this should be acknowledged.
- For Foucault the gaze concerns disciplinary knowledge / power.

The male gaze

- Laura Mulvey developed the idea of the male gaze, that visual media position women as objects of male desire and control.
- In cinema / television / visual culture the camera can adopt a heterosexual male perspective, with women as passive objects rather than active subjects.
- Not just media, but wider social structures in terms of how women's bodies are perceived and hence controlled.

Section B (Spring Term)



Rethinking Modernity: Sociology of Media and Culture

1. Mass Society and Mass Culture Debate

Popular culture entered intellectual debate as a problem: a perceived threat to moral order, social authority, and democratic stability. It is still seen as a contemporary problem. Examples of this include:-

- The moral panic over music genres (Punk, Drill)
- Concerns about social media / smartphone use / 'Brain rot' memes
- Moralism concerning what children are reading (or not reading, debates on education about the teaching of English Literature / Latin in schools)
- Culture wars - that high culture is being driven out by popular culture
- Fears over populism / 'mob rule' / democratisation

This debate was concerned with mass society (industrialisation / urbanisation / capitalism / atomisation) had brought about mass culture (produced for the masses) which alongside mass democratisation and mass education would bring about civilisational decline.

The debate is best understood through the work of four key intellectual positions Matthew Arnold, F. R. Leavis (and Q. D. Leavis), and later sociological / cultural theorists, particularly Raymond Williams and Stuart Hall, who we will also discuss later.

Matthew Arnold

Matthew Arnold's *Culture and Anarchy* (1869) establishes the intellectual foundations of what later becomes known as the "**culture and civilisation**" tradition. Arnold defines culture as "the best that has been thought and said," a formulation that is explicitly hierarchical and normative. Culture, for Arnold, is not a description of everyday practices or popular tastes; it is a moral ideal. Arnold's fear is not simply social change, but what he calls "anarchy": the erosion of shared moral standards and the weakening of institutions capable of guiding collective life. Culture becomes a corrective to democracy rather than its expression. Rather than trusting popular opinion, Arnold argues that cultural authority should restrain and educate the masses. In this sense, culture functions as a form of moral governance, designed to compensate for the perceived dangers of mass democracy. Importantly, Arnold's critique targets not only the working class but also middle-class individualism and aristocratic rigidity; nevertheless, his framework assumes that cultural value must be defined by a minority with superior judgement. Arnold's solution is 'sweetness' and 'light' (intelligence of a certain, cultivated kind – light – to illuminate beauty – sweetness).

F. R. and Q. D. Leavis

Leavis usually refers to F.R. Leavis, but his wife also adopted his ideas. F. R. Leavis develops the most influential and controversial version of this critique. In *Mass Civilisation and Minority Culture* (1930). In *Culture and Environment* (with Denys Thompson), Leavis frames literary education as a form of cultural defence: studying English literature becomes a means of cultivating moral discrimination and resisting the standardising effects of mass communication.

Q. D. Leavis complements this moral critique with an empirical analysis in *Fiction and the Reading Public* (1939). Examining publishing markets and readership patterns, she argues that commercial pressures transform literature into a commodity, privileging formulaic genres

over serious fiction. While deeply pessimistic, her work anticipates later sociological concerns with cultural industries, commodification, and audience formation (see also Frankfurt school for a Marxist critique of the culture industry). Together, they present mass culture as a symptom of social decline and position cultural elites, and a particular form of education, as necessary guardians of value.

Possible Critiques

- a. Taste is not objective and a matter of cultural judgement, routed in class inequalities (Bourdieu)
- b. 'Culture is ordinary' (Raymond Williams) and not just the preserve of a elite class.
- c. Popular culture is negotiated / produced in varying media conditions of governance and regulation.
- d. Popular culture is not always 'mass culture' and is fragmented and can reflect 'folk cultures'

Stuart Hall

Hall does not deny that culture is shaped by power, capitalism, and inequality. Instead, he challenges the assumption that popular culture is either a degraded mass product or an authentic expression of "the people." In "Notes on Deconstructing 'the Popular,'" Hall reconceptualises popular culture as a contested terrain, a site of ongoing struggle between dominant institutions and subordinate groups. Hall's intervention breaks with classical mass culture theory in two ways. First, he rejects the idea of passive audiences. Drawing on reception theory, Hall argues that media texts are polysemic: they can be interpreted in dominant, negotiated, or oppositional ways depending on social position and experience. Second, he introduces the idea of relative autonomy. Culture operates within structural constraints but is never fully determined by them.

2. Marx, Ideology, and the Frankfurt School

Marx, ideology and culture

- Marx was a polymath who was not only a writer and philosopher but also wrote fiction, poetry, and worked for radical newspapers as well as submitting articles to more popular magazines and newspapers. He was hence personally engaged in the production of wider culture, particularly reporting on worker's movements and other radical movements across Europe.
- Marx's work was not really about culture, but there are many references to ideology and the role of aspects of culture within it, what it means to be a worker in the cultural industries (for example, as an actor or as a musician) and whether cultural forms, compared to other forms of action, were a form of class consciousness.
- Marx was prolific. We often distinguish between the 'early' and 'late / mature' Marx (Grundrisse – outlines / Das Kapital). The early works of Marx focussed on ideology as an ideology imposed by the ruling class, and slightly later as reliant on the relationship between the economic base and superstructure. The later works of Marx, Capital, is a Critique of Political Economy using concepts such as labour power, alienation, industry and commodification.

Marx - The German Ideology (1846)

Ruling class ideas and the ‘means of mental production’

‘The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas, i.e. the class which is the ruling material force of society, is at the same time its ruling intellectual force. The class which has the means of production at its disposal, has control at the same time over the means of mental production, so that thereby, generally speaking, the ideas of those who lack the means of mental production are subject to it.’

- Different ruling class in different epochs (Slavery – Kings and Pharaohs; Feudal – Kings and Lords; Capitalism – Capitalists). Current epoch – capitalism
- Rules in terms of materiality (economics) but also in terms of the sphere of ideas
- Means of mental production (schools, books, libraries, cultural forms), how working class mentality is produced
- Ideology is seen as arising from the ruling class as a form of ruling class similar to those in previous epochs – capitalism is different but still top-down ideology

Contemporary example of control of means of mental production

-Monopolisation of record companies, streaming services, ticket agencies and retailers. Cross-ownership of companies such as Amazon (retailer, online) that also owns streaming services. This enables the control of ‘mental production’ by capitalists.

How ideology inverts (from German ideology)

“If in all ideology men and their circumstances appear upside-down as in a camera obscura, this phenomenon arises just as much from their historical life-process as the inversion of objects on the retina does from their physical life-process”.

Ideology represents class relations in an illusory form in so far as these ideas do not accurately portray the nature and relative positions of the classes concerned; rather, ideology misrepresents these relations in a way which concurs with the interests of the dominant class.

-When we see something, our eyes invert the image and this is also how cameras work (camera obscura), it inverts the historical life processes of individuals. An example of this would be that ruling class individuals (such as Richard Branson, who set up Virgin records) is rich and successful because he is clever and talented whereas the material basis of this is the exploitation of labour – of artists and musicians who make the music that he sells – over their historical (entire) lives. This inversion concurs with the interests of the dominant class.

Marx – Contribution to a Critique of Political Economy (1859)

Base and Superstructure

-Looking at not just ruling class dominating the means of mental production, but also at what happens in the economic base. The superstructure (political-legal, originally, the state) arises from the economic base. Engels (in Anti-Dühring – response to Dühring, a German social democrat, Engels is putting forward the argument for Marxism as a science) later extended this to include forms of culture, and the media, arise from this base. Engels and later economists such as Althusser introduced concepts of determination in the last instance (not

immediate, only determined over a long period of history), relative autonomy (some independence from it) and overdetermination (lots of different economic and historical events leading to outcomes).

Marx – Capital: A Critique of Political Economy (Three volumes) (1867, 1885, 1894)

- Capital – three volumes (4 with theories of surplus value), finished by Engels after death
- Critique of political economy – not a new political economy (Marxist / Socialist) a critique of economics as a new science mystification etc
- Examines material conditions of production – critiques capitalism and idealism
- Used in terms of artists / musicians becoming labourers, producing cultural commodities in order to survive. Ruling class profit from their exploitation and build capital.

Adorno and Horkheimer – Dialectic of Enlightenment (1947)

- Frankfurt school – Institute for Social Research University of Frankfurt (founded 1923) rise of Nazism, moved to Geneva (1933) and then New York (1935) – established critical theory, dominant ideology as ruling class ideology (cultural hegemony, hegemonic, total and unified ruling class ideas and the structure of ideas). Critical as opposed to traditional theory (not scientific method – facts are based on historical context of their formation and historical context of the perceiver). Self-critical, no claim to universal truth, does not privilege materialism or idealism – methods from Marxism particularly the dialectic. Totalising philosophy also incorporated mass psychology / psychoanalysis
- Dialectic – thesis (argument), anti-thesis (counterargument) – synthesis (new, more developed understanding).
- Enlightenment dialectic is reason / science (thesis) against myth (antithesis) but has produced (synthesis) control / domination / rationalisation leading to new myth that hierarchies / control through science / technology.
- Total control of the population - Nazism / Stalinism / State capitalism / Culture Industry
Compares enlightenment to a dictatorship – man of science knows things so that he can control them
- Media impresses standardised behaviour / consumption on the individual as rational. Only freedom is freedom of the industrialists / monopolists.
- Essay – The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception ‘Culture today is infecting everything with sameness’, standardisation and mass production, details become interchangeable
- Culture no longer has to present itself as art, it is business.
- Media operates through standardisation / pseudo-individuation and catharsis.
- ‘Entertainment is the prolongation of work under late capitalism. It is sought by those who want to escape the mechanised labour process so they can experience it again’
- Something is provided for everyone, differences are hammered home and propagated
- The star system propagates the ideology that the ‘ordinary person’ can make it
- Enlightenment control / rationality leads to dictatorship / fascism as culture industries encourage.
- ‘Enlightenment itself, having mastered itself and assumed its own power, could break through the limits of Enlightenment’ (producing something worse, Fascism)

Benjamin - The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction (1935)

- Mass production / mechanical reproduction (in capitalism) reduces the 'aura' of art in that it is disconnected from where the art was made (locale) and its cultural and physical context. So this is disconnected from the reproduction.
- BUT it changes the ways in which art is consumed. High art is consumed for its cult status and its value in an exhibition (cult value and exhibition value). Mechanical reproduction voids those values but creates new values / ways of seeing. For example, through popular cinema people take the perspective of the camera. Through the consumption of music in clubs, people dance to music.

Now individuals can experience art in different ways, to think critically about the world and to consider a different life. Means of production of art democratised.

3. Habermas and the Public Sphere

Context

-Marx on ideology – Early Marx (ruling class, mental means of production, base and superstructure)
 -Frankfurt school – Adorno and Horkheimer, dialectic of enlightenment, culture, culture industry, standardisation, pseudo-individualization, catharsis. Sceptical on revolution, state-capitalism / fascism, reduces role of agency (perhaps some in the Bad Infinity – people become bored of repetition or via the avant-garde)
 BUT Walter Benjamin art and mechanical reproduction, Art having cult and exhibition value, mass production gives possibility of different perceptions, new means of production so possible agency within culture. AND Jurgen Habermas – public sphere as possible sphere for democratisation

Jurgen Habermas (1929-)

Habermas' account of the public sphere can be understood as a two-part narrative: the emergence of a liberal bourgeois public sphere; and its eventual refeudalisation by the state and commercial private interests.

The idea of the public sphere can be understood as a public forum for rational and critical debate. Whilst such forums date from Classical Greece, they assumed a new and distinctive form in the 17th and 18th centuries, particularly in Britain where there occurred a rapidly developing capitalist economy, a reconstituted public state, and the establishment of a bourgeois civil society.

It's between this newly reconstituted realm of public authority and the private realm of civil society that there emerges a new sphere of the public, a space in which a body of private persons can assemble to discuss matters of public concern or common interest. In particular, the public sphere created a forum in which the authority of the state could be criticized and called upon to justify itself before an informed and reasoning public.

Public life was now a theatre in which the authorities (the monarch, aristocracy and church) occasionally displayed their power on ceremonial occasions.

“By the public sphere we mean first of all a realm of our social life in which something approaching public opinion can be formed. Access is guaranteed to all citizens. A portion of the public sphere comes into being in every conversation in which private individuals assemble to form a public body. In a large public body, this kind of communication requires specific means for transmitting information and influencing those who receive it. Today, newspapers and magazines, radio and television are the media of the public sphere.”

The Ideal Speech Situation

Anybody with the competence to speak be allowed to take part in a discussion
Anyone is allowed to question any assertion whatsoever in that discussion.
Anyone is allowed to introduce any assertion whatever into that discussion.
No person be prevented from exercising their rights to freedom of expression.
That the consensus of opinion be decided by the most rational argument.

Some Criticisms

1. Although the public sphere was based on the principle of universal access, in practice it was premised on significant structural exclusions
2. Habermas places too much emphasis on the bourgeois public sphere, ignoring the significance of other forms of public discourse and popular social movements.
3. There are problems with Habermas’ argument concerning the decline of the public sphere and the concept of refeudalisation, is this just part of the continuation of capitalism
4. Habermas tends to treat the recipients of media messages as passive consumers unless they have access to the Public Sphere

Fraser’s critique of the public sphere

Fraser, N. (1999) ‘Rethinking the Public Sphere: A Contribution to the Critique of Actually Existing Democracy’, Dunning, S. (Ed.), *The Cultural Studies Reader*, London: Routledge, pp518-536.

Nancy Fraser’s critique of the public sphere represents one of the most influential feminist and critical interventions into democratic theory in the late twentieth century. Writing in *Rethinking the Public Sphere: A Contribution to the Critique of Actually Existing Democracy* (1999), Fraser challenges the dominant Habermasian model of the public sphere, arguing that it is both empirically inaccurate and normatively exclusionary. Her intervention is not a rejection of the public sphere as such, but rather a reconstruction of it—one that accounts for power, inequality, and social difference within “actually existing” democracies. In doing so, Fraser offers a more pluralistic and conflict-aware understanding of public discourse and democratic participation.

Fraser’s critique is directed primarily at Jürgen Habermas’s classical formulation of the bourgeois public sphere, which presents it as a space of rational-critical debate among private individuals, oriented toward the common good and free from domination. While Habermas acknowledged that this ideal was historically limited, Fraser argues that his model nevertheless continues to function as a normative benchmark that obscures systemic exclusions. According to Fraser, the bourgeois public sphere was never as inclusive, egalitarian, or disinterested as it claimed to be. Women, the working class, racialised minorities, and other subordinated groups were structurally excluded, not accidentally

marginalised. Thus, the supposed universality of the public sphere was built upon social inequalities that were bracketed rather than eliminated.

A central component of Fraser's critique concerns the assumption that social inequalities can be "bracketed" in public deliberation. Habermas suggests that participants can set aside differences in status and power in order to deliberate as equals. Fraser rejects this as unrealistic and ideologically naïve. She argues that inequalities rooted in class, gender, race, and sexuality inevitably shape who can speak, who is heard, and whose arguments are taken seriously. Discursive norms that privilege particular styles of speech such as calm rationality, abstraction, and dispassion—often function to disadvantage subordinated groups whose communicative practices may differ. As a result, formally open public spheres can still reproduce domination through informal mechanisms of exclusion.

Fraser also challenges the idea of a singular, unified public sphere. The Habermasian model assumes that the public sphere should be one comprehensive arena in which citizens deliberate together. Fraser argues instead that this ideal suppresses difference and benefits dominant groups. In stratified societies, a single public sphere tends to reflect the perspectives and interests of those already in power, while marginalising countervailing viewpoints. For Fraser, plurality is not a democratic deficit but a democratic necessity. The expectation that all participants converge in one space on shared norms of discourse risks silencing oppositional voices rather than integrating them.

In place of a singular public sphere, Fraser introduces the concept of *subaltern counterpublics*. These are alternative discursive arenas formed by members of subordinated social groups in which they can develop oppositional interpretations of their identities, interests, and needs. Examples include feminist publics, Black publics, and queer publics. Counterpublics serve a dual function: they provide spaces of withdrawal and regroupment, and they act as bases for agitation directed toward wider publics. Rather than being inherently separatist or anti-democratic, counterpublics are, for Fraser, essential to participatory parity in conditions of structural inequality.

Another major aspect of Fraser's critique concerns the distinction between public and private. The classical bourgeois public sphere relied on a sharp separation between public matters of common concern and private matters of family, sexuality, and domestic life. Fraser argues that this division has historically functioned to depoliticise issues that disproportionately affect women and other subordinated groups. By defining matters such as domestic violence, reproductive rights, and care work as "private," dominant publics excluded them from legitimate political debate. Fraser insists that what counts as a matter of public concern is itself a political question, not a neutral or pre-given boundary.

Fraser further critiques the assumption that the public sphere should be oriented exclusively toward the common good rather than particular interests. She argues that this distinction is misleading, since claims presented as universal often mask the particular interests of dominant groups. Subordinated groups, by contrast, are frequently criticised for being "self-interested" when they articulate their needs. Fraser contends that democratic legitimacy does not require the elimination of interests but rather fair conditions under which competing interests can be articulated and contested. Democratic deliberation should therefore be understood as inherently conflictual, not consensual.

4. Culture is ordinary (British Cultural Studies)

Introduction

- Cultural studies
- Emerged from a critical dialogue between the cultural theory of Leavisism and classical Marxism.
- Foundational texts in this tradition include the works of Richard Hoggart, Raymond Williams, and E. P. Thompson, published in the late 1950s and early 1960s.
- A central theme uniting their work is an emphasis on human agency

Origins

- British Cultural Studies emerges in the post-war period, roughly from the late 1950s onward.
- Britain at this point is undergoing a profound transformation. The Second World War has ended, the welfare state is expanding, higher education is no longer the preserve of a tiny elite, and mass media is becoming a dominant force in everyday life.
- This is a Britain in which class still matters enormously, but its cultural forms are changing. Traditional working-class communities are being reshaped by urban redevelopment, consumer capitalism, and new forms of entertainment such as television, popular music, advertising.
- Up until this point, culture had often been treated in one of two unsatisfactory ways. On the one hand, in elite literary traditions, culture meant “high culture” Shakespeare, opera, classical music — something refined, elevated, and clearly separated from everyday life. On the other hand, in some forms of Marxism, culture was treated as little more than a reflection of the economic base – Marx / Frankfurt school.
- British Cultural Studies rejects both positions. Instead, it argues that culture is ordinary, lived, contested, and deeply political.
- Rejection of cultural pessimism on the one hand, and cultural celebration on the other.
- Cultural Studies is not simply about analysing films or music for their own sake. It is about understanding culture as a site of struggle.
- Shaped by the expansion of adult education and working-class access to universities in post-war Britain.
- Crystallises with the founding of the Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies, or CCCS, at the University of Birmingham in 1964. CCCS becomes an intellectual hub for a new, interdisciplinary approach.

E. P. Thompson and the Foundations of Cultural Studies

- Thompson’s historical sociology profoundly shaped how culture, class, and power came to be understood within the field.
- His insistence on lived experience, historical specificity, and human agency provided a crucial alternative to structuralist and economic approaches, influencing generations of scholars concerned with culture as a site of struggle rather than mere reflection.
- Culture as Lived Experience
- History from Below and Cultural Agency
- Moral Economy and Cultural Conflict

Raymond Williams: Culture and Society

- Rather than treating culture as the preserve of art, literature, or intellectual achievement, Williams famously insisted that culture should be understood as a “whole way of life.”
- For Williams, culture encompassed everyday practices, values, institutions, meanings, and forms of communication through which social life is organised. This shift made it possible to study popular culture, media, and ordinary social experience as serious objects of analysis rather than as degraded or secondary forms.
- Williams developed this position most clearly in *Culture and Society* (1958)
- Pre-emergent cultural experiences of a class not yet articulated in formal ideology
- Culture was not a timeless category. but a contested concept shaped by specific historical struggles.
- A key feature of Williams’s work is his resistance to determinism. While he was deeply influenced by Marxism, he rejected versions that treated culture as a simple reflection of economic structures.
- One of Williams’s most influential conceptual contributions is the idea of “structure of feeling.” This concept was developed to capture social experiences that are lived and felt but not yet fully articulated in formal institutions or dominant ideologies. Structures of feeling refer to shared, emergent ways of sensing and understanding the world that arise during periods of social change.
- In works such as *Communications* (1962) and *Television: Technology and Cultural Form* (1974), he challenged technological determinism, particularly the view that media technologies themselves dictate social outcomes. Instead, he argued that technologies are developed and used within specific social and political contexts.
- His concept of “flow” in television analysis demonstrated how broadcasting operates as a continuous sequence rather than a series of discrete programmes, shaping how audiences experience media in everyday life. This approach treated media as embedded in social relations rather than as neutral tools or autonomous forces.
- The concept of flow also has implications for how meaning is produced. Because television is experienced as a sequence, meanings emerge cumulatively rather than in isolation

Richard Hoggart (1918-)

- Literacy can be applied to all aspects of culture – particularly ‘reading’ working class culture. Working class people who ascend into education / Universities feel a cultural separation.
- 1930s reflects a so-called ‘lived’, ‘self-made’ culture
- 1950s culture is marked by the demands of commercialisation and mass production: ‘a world where things are done for the people’.

Stuart Hall

- Draws heavily on the Italian Marxist Antonio Gramsci, particularly his concept of hegemony.
- Hegemony refers to the process by which dominant groups secure consent rather than relying purely on force. Power works not just through laws or police, but through common sense through ideas that feel natural, inevitable, and beyond question.

- 1973 essay “Encoding and Decoding in the Television Discourse.” In this model, Hall rejected the idea that media messages have fixed meanings that are simply transmitted to audiences.
- Encoding and decoding. This model challenges the idea that media messages have fixed meanings that are simply transmitted to passive audiences. Dominant (hegemonic), negotiated, oppositional (see model)
- In ‘The Whites of Their Eyes: Racist Ideologies and the Media’ Hall talks about ‘grammar of racism’ on television and encoding ‘Love Thy Neighbour’ - was based around a white working class couple (Eddie and Joan Booth) living in Twickenham, in the outer London suburbs, and a black couple (Bill and Barbie Reynolds) as their next-door neighbours
- *Policing the Crisis: Mugging, the State, and Law and Order* (1978), authored by Stuart Hall and colleagues at the Birmingham Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies (CCCS), is one of the most influential works in British cultural studies and critical sociology.
- How a relatively limited phenomenon, a moral panic, street robbery, labelled as “mugging” became a major political and moral issue in 1970s Britain.
- Media, policing, and state power interact to produce ideological responses to wider social and economic crises.

5. Structuralism and Cultural Signs

Saussure

- Language is not a collection of names for things. It is a structured system of differences. To explain this, Saussure introduces what becomes one of the most influential ideas in twentieth-century theory: the sign. Every sign, he argues, is made up of two inseparable components.
- Signifier. This is the physical form of the sign: the sound you hear when a word is spoken, the marks you see on a page (later applied to images, styles)
- Signified. This is the concept associated with the signifier—not the thing itself, but the mental idea of it.
- Culturalist - lived experience, historical context, and agency. Structuralist - the deep structures that organise meaning.
- This model can be applied beyond language but also in terms of images, fashion, food, advertising, film, news, and popular culture.

Barthes

- Barthes argues that in modern culture, signs often operate at two levels, not just one (sign / signifier).
- The first level is denotation. This is the most literal, descriptive level of meaning. What we might call “what we see”. At the level of denotation, this appears neutral and factual.
- At the second level, we have connotation. This is where cultural associations, values, and emotions come into play. The man does not simply wear a suit. The suit connotes professionalism, success, authority. The car does not simply exist. It connotes freedom, masculinity, status, aspiration.
- Myth, for Barthes, is a mode of signification. A myth is a way of making historically specific, culturally constructed meanings appear natural, timeless, and obvious.

Semiology and semiotics

- Semiology is the study of signs in society (not just linguistic signs)
- Semiotics (or semiology) is the study of signs, symbols, and signification. It is the study of how meaning is created.
- Elements that can be altered and still retain the same meaning

Critique and the work of Stuart Hall

Structuralism is extremely powerful at explaining how meaning is organised, but it is much less good at explaining power and inequality in concrete social contexts, media institutions and production and audience interpretation and resistance Hall was deeply influenced by Saussure and Barthes. He does not abandon structuralism. Instead, he reworks it, combining semiology with Marxism, ideology theory, and sociology.

6. Postmodernism

From Structuralism to post-structuralism and post-modernism

Structuralism – single and stable meaning, objective reality, epistemology

Post-structuralism: meaning is not stable, dependent on interpretation, multiple truths and meanings, reality is socially constructed, no universal truth.

Post-modernism: after modernity, many movements including post-structuralism. May suggest post-modern methods of resistance or nihilism.

Modernism – grand narratives, truth through science and investigation, mass media and unified systems of control

Post-modernism – breakdown of this (crisis, wars, fall of Communism, technology, media)

Postmodern styles

In architecture, cinema, television, video games. A breakdown of narratives of high / low culture.

Lyotard

Jean-François Lyotard's *The Postmodern Condition* (1979) argues that postmodernity is defined by a growing disbelief in "grand narratives"—the big stories that once claimed to explain and justify knowledge, progress, and social order (such as Enlightenment rationality, Marxism, or Christianity).

Lyotard on post-modernism

Postmodernity is a condition in which knowledge is fragmented, instrumentalised, and no longer justified by universal truths, but by efficiency, usefulness, and local rules.

Lyotard on media

For Lyotard, postmodernity is marked by the breakdown of unified truth. Media play a central role in this.

Media no longer transmit a shared worldview. Instead, they circulate discrete, competing messages. No single media narrative can claim authority over others

Media become part of a landscape of plural language games, not a source of consensus. Performativity governs media

Baudrillard

Sign value

Shift from Marxist conception of value (use / exchange) to sign value – the signification implied in the transaction ‘The sign object is neither given nor exchanged: it is appropriated, withheld and manipulated by individual subjects as a sign, that is as a coded difference’ (Simulacra and Simulation).

Hypermarket

Modern shopping centre based in the heart of a community, now based in its own area, now out of the city creates its own spatial / temporal distortions like a satellite having gravitational pull. Generates new geographical and experiential space (and new modes of living).

Consumers who pass through this space are screened and tested, surveilled and noted in terms of their consumption. Yet behaviour is playful and whimsical.

Hyperreality

In third order simulation the hyperreal proceeds the real but this does not mean that there’s a blurring of these rather the reversal becomes irrelevant. Hyperreal is measured by performativity, how well does it operate.

Disneyland

Disneyland – We tend to think of this as a fantasy representation, exaggeration of features of reality, based on the work of Walt Disney, films and cartoons. Disneyland as a third order simulation – the hyperreal. Measured in terms of performativity, how well does it operate, like a real city Prisons – hide the fact that we are all incarcerated in society. Disneyland exists to conceal the fact that it is the real America Operates like a deterrence machine to conceal the fact that the real is no longer real.

‘Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest is real, when in fact all of Los Angeles and the America surrounding it are no longer real, but of the order of the hyperreal and simulation’

Political scandals

Watergate (political scandal) – Baudrillard argues that it is not a scandal but exists as the hyperreal to covers up that Government / capitalism itself is corrupt and a scandal – an aberration. Attempts dissimulation ‘...an imaginary effect, like Disneyland, concealing that reality no more exists outside than inside the bounds of an artificial parameter’

Simulation – to feign / pretend (eg pretending one is sick by making oneself sick) – gap between the two collapses. Dissimulation – reveal the pretence. Political scandal is a pretence that government is not scandalous. Baudrillard argues that it’s not possible to dissimulate gives the example of simulating an armed robbery (not possible as to simulate would be to conduct an armed robbery).

Gulf war did not take place

Gulf war was overwhelming strength (like a pre-programmed war), using US technology and broadcast 'live' The war was a postmodern act to see if war was possible in the current age. Shrinking of perspective (audience were there) and imagery so not possible to say if it happened or not.

Reality TV

Real and represented are identical – they implode into one thing, no perceptual distance. The eye of TV is no longer a panoptic gaze, the gaze is invited and is the 'test', 'YOU are the content' the end of the panopticon. Media stages reality

Jameson's critique of post-modernism

Postmodern theory and culture are the primary form of cultural production in Late Capitalism in art, architecture, literature and film. These produce an ahistoricism where texts become styles and history is represented through pastiche. Alternative (utopian) trajectories for a system other than capitalism collapse into mere fads, narratives, or vague fantasies.

7. Gramsci and the turn to hegemony

Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937) was an Italian Marxist writing in the context of early 20th-century Europe, marked by mass politics, failed socialist revolutions in Western Europe, and the rise of fascism. His work emerged from a central problem in Marxism: why capitalist societies secured popular stability despite deep inequality. Gramsci wrote most of his theory in prison under Mussolini, producing the Prison Notebooks, which focus on culture, ideology, and power rather than economic determinism alone.

Hegemony

Hegemony refers to the way a dominant social group maintains power primarily through consent rather than coercion. For Gramsci, ruling groups succeed when their values, beliefs, and interests are accepted as common sense by society as a whole. Hegemony is cultural and moral leadership, not just political control, and it must be continuously produced and renewed.

Hegemony and Consent

At the heart of Gramsci's contribution is the concept of hegemony. Hegemony refers to the way a dominant social group maintains power not primarily through force, but through consent. This is a crucial shift. Power, for Gramsci, does not operate only through the state, the police, or the military.

Hegemony involves the more or less active consent of large sections of the population. Hegemony does not designate a particular ideology or even the ruling ideas in society but rather a process of management and administration. Hegemony is not something imposed on society from above so much as generated from below

Culture is not a passive reflection of economic power, but an active terrain of struggle. Newspapers, films, television, education, and everyday language all play a role in shaping how people understand the world.

Common Sense and Good Sense

Common sense is the everyday, taken-for-granted set of beliefs through which people understand the world. It is historically produced, often contradictory, and shaped by dominant groups.

Good sense refers to the critical and reflective elements within common sense that can challenge dominant ideas. Hegemonic struggle involves shaping common sense while suppressing or marginalising good sense.

Gramsci defines intellectuals broadly as those who organise ideas and meaning in society.

Traditional intellectuals see themselves as neutral or independent.

Organic intellectuals emerge from specific social groups and articulate their interests.

Media professionals (journalists, editors, cultural producers) can function as organic intellectuals by shaping narratives, values, and social norms.

Media as a Site of Hegemonic Struggle

From a Gramscian perspective, media does not simply transmit information; it constructs reality through framing, representation, and repetition.

Media normalises particular explanations of social issues (for example, individual responsibility over structural causes), helping to stabilise hegemonic common sense while managing dissent within acceptable limits.

Hall applied Gramsci's theories in his own analysis – as well as incorporating elements of structuralism.